

Guide to beating resume screening algorithms and getting past ATS to human reviewers — Action Checklist

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EXTRACT JOB POSTING KEYWORDS

- ☐ **Copy and Paste:** Transfer the entire job posting text into a separate document so you can annotate and analyze every section without losing context or formatting.
- ☐ **Highlight Hard Requirements:** Identify every non-negotiable criterion like degrees, certifications, years of experience, and specific tools by searching for must-have language.
- ☐ **Identify Soft Preferences:** Find skills framed as beneficial but not mandatory by looking for words like preferred, ideal, or bonus in the job posting.
- ☐ **Examine LinkedIn Profiles:** Review 3-5 profiles of people currently working in your target role at similar companies to discover industry terms not in the posting.

RESEARCH INDUSTRY LANGUAGE

- ☐ **Build Your Master Keyword List:** Compile every noun, phrase, and technical term from hard requirements, soft preferences, and industry shorthand into one searchable document.
- ☐ **Add Exact Phrasing to Your List:** Include the precise language used in the job posting because ATS systems match exact text rather than conceptual equivalents.
- ☐ **Map Accomplishments to Numbers:** Replace vague descriptions like led a team with specific data points including team size, percentage improvements, and timeframes for ATS parsing.
- ☐ **Verify Every Keyword Appears:** Cross-reference your master list against your resume to confirm each term shows up somewhere in your work history or skills section.

RESTRUCTURE RESUME CONTENT

- ☐ **Quantify Impact Statements:** Turn general claims into machine-readable data by including before-and-after metrics, dollar amounts, or percentage improvements for every accomplishment.
 - ☐ **Align Vocabulary Exactly:** Mirror the phrasing from job requirements verbatim on your resume so ATS systems recognize your qualifications without needing interpretation.
 - ☐ **Check Structural Formatting:** Remove tables, graphics, columns, headers, or footers that ATS systems cannot parse correctly and may cause your content to be skipped entirely.
 - ☐ **Test Format Compatibility:** Save your resume as a plain text document to verify all keywords and formatting survived the conversion before submitting online.
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